

## ABSTRACT

## Predicting NCAA March Madness Outcomes

The aim of this project is to develop a machine learning framework to predict outcomes for the NCAA Division I Mens Basketball Tournament. The purpose is to build upon traditional statistical rankings by implementing an automated pipeline that generates precise win probabilities for every possible tournament matchup. Extensive research into historical sports forecasting and modern machine learning techniques was conducted to establish a baseline for predictive accuracy and model calibration.

Following a comprehensive review of existing literature, the models were constructed using R. The primary dataset includes historical game results and Massey Ordinals, supplemented by custom feature engineering designed to capture team momentum and efficiency metrics. Four different modeling techniques were evaluated on the training data: Logistic Regression, Linear Regression, Random Forest, and XGBoost.

Unlike standard classification tasks, the final model was evaluated based on its ability to minimize the Brier Score, ensuring that the predicted probabilities were well calibrated against actual tournament results. The findings indicate that the integration of ensemble methods and strength of schedule adjustments provides a competitive edge in forecasting the high variance environment of the tournament. The complete codebase and dataset configurations are hosted on GitHub for further research and reproducibility. (do i put the link here or somewhere else)

Jonathen Marin  
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Predicting NCAA March Madness Outcomes

by

Jonathen Marin

A project

submitted in partial

fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of

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APPROVED

For the Department of Mathematics:

We, the undersigned, certify that the project of the following student meets the required standards of scholarship, format, and style of the university and the student's graduate degree program for the awarding of the master's degree.

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## INTRODUCTION

The National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) serves as the premier developmental system for the National Basketball Association (NBA) and the Women's National Basketball Association (WNBA). With thousands of athletes across both divisions arriving from around the world, the influence of the NCAA is extensive. As the basketball world has evolved into a multibillion dollar industry [?], the value of a competitive edge has become substantial. Teams historically relied on live scouting and film study to gain these advantages. However, the last decade has seen a major shift toward statistical findings. Inspired largely by the movie *Moneyball*, teams now look to analytics to uncover value that the naked eye might miss.

The focal point of this competitive landscape is March Madness. At the conclusion of the regular season, the selection committee invites 68 teams to participate in this tournament. The field includes the champions from all 32 Division I conferences alongside the best remaining teams chosen at large. The committee seeds these participants into four distinct regions with rankings ranging from 1 to 16. The four teams judged to be the strongest are awarded the number 1 seeds while the next tier receives the number 2 seeds. Within each region, the teams compete in a single elimination format where matchups are initially determined by rank. For example, the top seed plays the sixteenth seed. The winner of each region advances to the Final Four to compete for the national championship. Crucially, these contests take place at neutral sites rather than on home courts. This structure creates a predictive challenge where volatility is the norm.

To evaluate these predictive challenges in a rigorous and competitive environment, this project utilizes the Kaggle March Machine Learning Mania competition as its primary experimental framework. Kaggle provides a unique platform where data scientists from across the globe compete to minimize error in tournament forecasts using historical data stretching back to 1985. Unlike traditional bracket challenges that reward binary picks, this competition requires the submission of win probabilities for every possible matchup in the tournament field. This shift from simple selection to probabilistic estimation allows for a more granular analysis of model performance and calibration. By using this structured setting, the research can leverage standardized datasets including team efficiency ratings and historical results to build a pipeline that is both reproducible and statistically sound.

This statistical consistency is possible because basketball is uniquely suited for machine learning applications. Both individual and collective performances are captured through a standardized set of metrics. Discrete variables such as points, steals, assists, and rebounds provide a consistent numerical foundation for analysis across different eras and levels of competition. This uniformity allows for the creation of structured datasets where team strength can be quantified and compared through objective performance indicators. By leveraging these recurring statistical patterns, machine learning models can identify underlying trends that govern game outcomes and team efficiency.

A basic assessment often relies on a record of wins and losses to infer the overall quality of a team. While these records serve as strong indicators,

they frequently fail to capture critical nuance. Furthermore, the single elimination structure of the tournament ensures that upsets remain a constant possibility regardless of historical dominance. A defining example occurred in when the top ranked Virginia Cavaliers entered the postseason with 31 wins and only 3 losses. They fell to the lowest ranked UMBC Retrievers by 20 points. Such outcomes demonstrate why simple heuristics fail in this environment.

This inherent volatility drives a massive secondary market focused on sports betting. As legal wagering expands globally, March Madness has evolved into one of the largest gambling events in the world with 3.1 billion dollars wagered in 2025 on tournament outcomes [?]. To manage this risk, bookmakers generate odds which serve as the industry standard for predictive accuracy. These odds represent a market consensus that attempts to price in every available variable from player injuries to historical trends. However, these lines are often influenced by public sentiment and profit margins rather than pure probability. Consequently, developing a model capable of outperforming these market established baselines represents the gold standard for predictive success.

This paper aims to construct a predictive framework capable of meeting this standard. The primary objective is to develop and evaluate distinct statistical models that minimize the Brier Score metric used in the Kaggle competition. By testing various algorithms against historical data, the research seeks to identify a strategy that generates a winning score. The final analysis benchmarks these models against competitor submissions that utilized multiple strategies including elo ratings, standard odds conversion,

and analysis rankings. Ultimately, the optimal model will be deployed in the upcoming 2026 March Madness tournament to compare its projections with live results.

Motivated by this challenge, substantial research has addressed the complexities of March Madness prediction. The majority of this work focuses on engineering feature sets for learning algorithms ranging from linear regression to more complex ensemble methods. While the Kaggle competition provides foundational game statistics, transforming these into effective predictors requires significant effort. The following subsection details the specific data types provided by the competition to establish this baseline. The final subsection we review existing literature with a primary focus on feature engineering. Finally, the paper details the implementation of distinct modeling techniques. This comparative analysis examines linear and logistic regression alongside additional statistical methods. These models are compared against one another and evaluated relative to the winning scores from prior competitions.

### Data Available

The highly quantifiable nature of basketball ensures that statistical data is both abundant and accessible. While the Kaggle competition permits participants to incorporate any external datasets they acquire, the organizers themselves provide a comprehensive archive. This repository includes over 30 distinct tables of historical data spanning more than three decades. All of the tables are separated by gender, with the only exception being the public rankings table. This is due to the fact that they only compiled mens rankings.

The data provided by Kaggle is split into regular season and postseason files. For the purposes of this project, the tournament phase is referred to as the playoffs. This research focuses primarily on the detailed results tables for both the regular season and the playoffs while also utilizing the essential rankings and seeding tables. Although the broader archive extends further back, the detailed game statistics required for this analysis commence in the 2003 season. Each entry in these tables provides a comprehensive statistical breakdown for both the winning and losing teams in every recorded matchup.

| Season | DayNum | WTeamID | WScore | LTeamID | LScore | WLoc | NumOT | WFGM | WFGA | WFGM3 | WFGA3 | WFTM | WFTA | WDR | WDR | WAsst | WTO | WSR | WBlk | WPF | LFGM | LFGA | LFGM3 | LFGA3 | LFTM | LFTA | LOR | LDR |
|--------|--------|---------|--------|---------|--------|------|-------|------|------|-------|-------|------|------|-----|-----|-------|-----|-----|------|-----|------|------|-------|-------|------|------|-----|-----|
| 2003   | 10     | 1104    | 68     | 1328    | 62     | N    | 0     | 27   | 58   | 3     | 14    | 11   | 18   | 14  | 24  | 13    | 23  | 7   | 1    | 22  | 22   | 53   | 2     | 10    | 16   | 22   | 10  | 22  |
| 2003   | 10     | 1272    | 79     | 1393    | 63     | N    | 0     | 26   | 62   | 8     | 20    | 10   | 19   | 15  | 28  | 16    | 13  | 4   | 4    | 18  | 24   | 67   | 6     | 24    | 9    | 20   | 20  | 25  |
| 2003   | 11     | 1296    | 73     | 1437    | 61     | N    | 0     | 24   | 58   | 8     | 18    | 17   | 29   | 17  | 26  | 15    | 10  | 5   | 2    | 25  | 22   | 73   | 3     | 26    | 14   | 23   | 31  | 22  |
| 2003   | 11     | 1296    | 56     | 1457    | 50     | N    | 0     | 18   | 38   | 3     | 9     | 17   | 31   | 6   | 19  | 11    | 12  | 14  | 2    | 18  | 18   | 49   | 6     | 22    | 8    | 15   | 17  | 20  |
| 2003   | 11     | 1400    | 77     | 1208    | 71     | N    | 0     | 30   | 61   | 6     | 14    | 11   | 13   | 17  | 22  | 12    | 14  | 4   | 4    | 20  | 24   | 62   | 6     | 16    | 17   | 27   | 21  | 15  |
| 2003   | 11     | 1458    | 81     | 1186    | 55     | H    | 0     | 26   | 57   | 6     | 12    | 23   | 27   | 12  | 24  | 12    | 9   | 9   | 3    | 18  | 20   | 46   | 3     | 11    | 12   | 17   | 6   | 22  |
| 2003   | 12     | 1161    | 89     | 1236    | 62     | H    | 0     | 23   | 55   | 2     | 8     | 32   | 39   | 13  | 18  | 14    | 17  | 11  | 1    | 25  | 19   | 41   | 4     | 15    | 20   | 28   | 9   | 21  |
| 2003   | 12     | 1186    | 75     | 1457    | 61     | N    | 0     | 28   | 62   | 4     | 14    | 15   | 21   | 13  | 35  | 19    | 19  | 7   | 2    | 21  | 20   | 59   | 4     | 17    | 17   | 23   | 8   | 25  |
| 2003   | 12     | 1194    | 71     | 1156    | 66     | N    | 0     | 28   | 58   | 5     | 11    | 10   | 18   | 9   | 22  | 9     | 17  | 9   | 2    | 23  | 24   | 52   | 6     | 18    | 12   | 27   | 13  | 26  |
| 2003   | 12     | 1458    | 84     | 1296    | 56     | H    | 0     | 32   | 67   | 5     | 17    | 15   | 19   | 14  | 22  | 11    | 6   | 12  | 0    | 13  | 23   | 52   | 3     | 14    | 7    | 12   | 9   | 23  |
| 2003   | 13     | 1166    | 106    | 1426    | 59     | H    | 0     | 41   | 69   | 15    | 25    | 9    | 13   | 15  | 29  | 21    | 11  | 10  | 6    | 16  | 17   | 52   | 4     | 11    | 12   | 17   | 8   | 15  |
| 2003   | 13     | 1202    | 74     | 1106    | 73     | N    | 0     | 29   | 51   | 7     | 13    | 9    | 11   | 6   | 21  | 18    | 15  | 7   | 1    | 5   | 29   | 63   | 10    | 22    | 5    | 5    | 13  | 16  |
| 2003   | 13     | 1237    | 66     | 1135    | 65     | N    | 0     | 26   | 66   | 5     | 19    | 9    | 13   | 21  | 23  | 15    | 17  | 12  | 3    | 17  | 24   | 56   | 6     | 19    | 11   | 17   | 14  | 21  |
| 2003   | 13     | 1323    | 76     | 1125    | 48     | H    | 0     | 25   | 56   | 10    | 23    | 16   | 23   | 8   | 35  | 18    | 13  | 14  | 19   | 13  | 18   | 64   | 8     | 24    | 4    | 8    | 14  | 26  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1125    | 83     | 1135    | 77     | N    | 1     | 30   | 70   | 11    | 31    | 12   | 15   | 15  | 18  | 22    | 16  | 18  | 5    | 21  | 28   | 69   | 4     | 15    | 17   | 27   | 20  | 27  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1156    | 78     | 1236    | 71     | N    | 0     | 27   | 46   | 10    | 18    | 14   | 24   | 8   | 25  | 18    | 15  | 2   | 6    | 18  | 23   | 50   | 7     | 20    | 18   | 24   | 6   | 17  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1161    | 81     | 1194    | 56     | H    | 0     | 22   | 48   | 5     | 12    | 32   | 43   | 16  | 32  | 13    | 24  | 5   | 3    | 19  | 21   | 65   | 2     | 13    | 12   | 19   | 16  | 18  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1186    | 82     | 1202    | 57     | H    | 0     | 33   | 61   | 8     | 19    | 8    | 14   | 9   | 23  | 21    | 17  | 14  | 5    | 18  | 23   | 55   | 2     | 11    | 9    | 14   | 13  | 23  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1183    | 73     | 1129    | 59     | A    | 0     | 29   | 59   | 9     | 19    | 6    | 8    | 8   | 21  | 17    | 15  | 10  | 1    | 19  | 21   | 51   | 3     | 14    | 14   | 18   | 12  | 22  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1314    | 85     | 1336    | 55     | H    | 0     | 32   | 60   | 5     | 15    | 16   | 23   | 12  | 34  | 18    | 14  | 8   | 4    | 12  | 21   | 71   | 3     | 23    | 10   | 11   | 15  | 20  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1323    | 89     | 1237    | 45     | H    | 0     | 34   | 62   | 8     | 16    | 13   | 21   | 12  | 34  | 25    | 11  | 9   | 13   | 16  | 18   | 74   | 4     | 15    | 5    | 11   | 27  | 22  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1353    | 69     | 1162    | 36     | H    | 0     | 23   | 57   | 4     | 19    | 10   | 15   | 15  | 18  | 10    | 12  | 14  | 6    | 18  | 12   | 39   | 3     | 8     | 9    | 13   | 11  | 23  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1390    | 61     | 1131    | 57     | H    | 0     | 20   | 53   | 6     | 27    | 15   | 24   | 15  | 24  | 9     | 14  | 4   | 2    | 17  | 19   | 54   | 3     | 17    | 16   | 18   | 11  | 22  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1426    | 59     | 1106    | 47     | N    | 0     | 25   | 53   | 1     | 5     | 8    | 12   | 15  | 32  | 14    | 16  | 6   | 4    | 7   | 20   | 60   | 6     | 18    | 1    | 2    | 8   | 15  |
| 2003   | 14     | 1462    | 87     | 1389    | 48     | H    | 0     | 35   | 70   | 6     | 19    | 11   | 16   | 17  | 27  | 18    | 7   | 13  | 3    | 10  | 20   | 63   | 7     | 20    | 1    | 4    | 16  | 18  |
| 2003   | 15     | 1161    | 77     | 1156    | 63     | H    | 0     | 27   | 58   | 5     | 10    | 18   | 27   | 18  | 26  | 15    | 12  | 5   | 4    | 21  | 23   | 51   | 3     | 13    | 14   | 20   | 7   | 19  |
| 2003   | 15     | 1194    | 93     | 1236    | 86     | N    | 2     | 33   | 75   | 9     | 20    | 18   | 33   | 17  | 26  | 14    | 14  | 17  | 0    | 21  | 27   | 58   | 14    | 31    | 18   | 22   | 9   | 33  |
| 2003   | 15     | 1196    | 76     | 1256    | 55     | H    | 0     | 28   | 48   | 4     | 13    | 16   | 24   | 8   | 23  | 18    | 18  | 13  | 5    | 19  | 19   | 49   | 1     | 5     | 16   | 22   | 12  | 17  |
| 2003   | 15     | 1242    | 81     | 1221    | 57     | H    | 0     | 28   | 53   | 3     | 5     | 22   | 37   | 13  | 29  | 12    | 19  | 10  | 3    | 21  | 18   | 52   | 7     | 21    | 14   | 21   | 8   | 22  |
| 2003   | 15     | 1422    | 84     | 1447    | 65     | H    | 0     | 33   | 53   | 3     | 8     | 15   | 20   | 7   | 36  | 12    | 22  | 5   | 9    | 19  | 26   | 70   | 3     | 25    | 10   | 16   | 14  | 15  |
| 2003   | 16     | 1314    | 71     | 1353    | 67     | H    | 0     | 27   | 57   | 5     | 14    | 12   | 19   | 14  | 30  | 19    | 20  | 8   | 5    | 13  | 27   | 66   | 9     | 22    | 4    | 11   | 12  | 19  |
| 2003   | 16     | 1390    | 63     | 1462    | 62     | H    | 0     | 23   | 57   | 6     | 15    | 11   | 21   | 17  | 20  | 12    | 10  | 8   | 1    | 19  | 18   | 45   | 6     | 20    | 20   | 28   | 11  | 17  |
| 2003   | 17     | 1196    | 99     | 1183    | 65     | H    | 0     | 39   | 73   | 11    | 28    | 10   | 22   | 16  | 31  | 32    | 14  | 10  | 14   | 19  | 22   | 66   | 4     | 11    | 17   | 24   | 15  | 23  |
| 2003   | 17     | 1304    | 68     | 1147    | 45     | N    | 0     | 27   | 58   | 6     | 18    | 8    | 13   | 10  | 28  | 13    | 17  | 5   | 5    | 26  | 10   | 50   | 2     | 16    | 23   | 31   | 16  | 24  |
| 2003   | 18     | 1104    | 82     | 1186    | 56     | H    | 0     | 24   | 48   | 10    | 20    | 24   | 34   | 12  | 26  | 13    | 13  | 7   | 3    | 14  | 19   | 55   | 8     | 21    | 10   | 12   | 11  | 18  |

Figure 1. Regular Season Detailed Data

This table records key performance metrics for each game played. The schema utilizes the prefix W to denote statistics for the winning team and the prefix L for the losing team. The specific recorded variables include:

- Points Scored
- The number of field goals made and attempted (FGM-A).
- The number of 3-point field goals made and attempted (FGM-A3).

- The number of free throws made and attempted (FTM-A).
- The number of offensive and defensive rebounds secured (OR- DR).
- The number of assists (Ast).
- The number of turnovers (TO).
- The number of blocks (Blk).
- The number of fouls (PF).

While raw box scores provide the foundation of events that happened in a game, they often fail to capture nuances in, and out, of the game. To address this limitation, this research supplements the Kaggle datasets with advanced metrics from analyst Ken Pomeroy (KenPom). Pomeroy is accepted as the industry standard for college basketball analysis. Pomeroy's approach is to normalize the data by calculating efficiency rather than raw stats. These statistics are updated daily throughout the regular season and tournament. For the purpose of this study, a snapshot of the rankings was acquired from the day prior to the start of the 2025 tournament.

| 2026 Pomeroy College Basketball Ratings                                    |              |      |      |        |       |       |      |       |                      |       |       |        |  |  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|------|------|--------|-------|-------|------|-------|----------------------|-------|-------|--------|--|--|
| help                                                                       |              |      |      |        |       |       |      |       |                      |       |       |        |  |  |
| 02-03-04-05-06-07-08-09-10-11-12-13-14-15-16-17-18-19-20-21-22-23-24-25-26 |              |      |      |        |       |       |      |       |                      |       |       |        |  |  |
| Data through games of Monday, January 19 (3689 games)                      |              |      |      |        |       |       |      |       |                      |       |       |        |  |  |
| Rk                                                                         | Team         | Conf | W-L  | NetRtg | ORTg  | DRtg  | AdjT | Luck  | Strength of Schedule |       |       | NCSOS  |  |  |
|                                                                            |              |      |      |        |       |       |      |       | NetRtg               | ORTg  | DRtg  |        |  |  |
| 1                                                                          | Michigan     | B10  | 16-1 | +36.00 | 127.0 | 91.0  | 73.5 | +0.22 | 11.23                | 116.6 | 105.4 | +11.45 |  |  |
| 2                                                                          | Arizona      | B12  | 18-0 | +34.04 | 126.9 | 92.9  | 71.8 | +0.33 | 6.59                 | 114.8 | 108.2 | +2.69  |  |  |
| 3                                                                          | Duke         | ACC  | 17-1 | +32.78 | 126.0 | 93.2  | 67.6 | +0.78 | 9.69                 | 115.7 | 106.0 | +6.04  |  |  |
| 4                                                                          | Purdue       | B10  | 17-1 | +31.31 | 129.5 | 98.2  | 65.9 | +0.87 | 9.41                 | 116.1 | 106.7 | +7.23  |  |  |
| 5                                                                          | Houston      | B12  | 17-1 | +31.14 | 124.1 | 93.0  | 63.6 | +0.54 | 5.44                 | 113.5 | 108.1 | +0.85  |  |  |
| 6                                                                          | Gonzaga      | WCC  | 19-1 | +31.04 | 126.3 | 95.2  | 70.3 | +0.96 | 5.48                 | 113.1 | 107.7 | +7.66  |  |  |
| 7                                                                          | Illinois     | B10  | 15-3 | +30.44 | 129.3 | 98.9  | 66.4 | +0.04 | 8.62                 | 115.5 | 106.9 | +3.56  |  |  |
| 8                                                                          | Iowa St.     | B12  | 16-2 | +30.00 | 125.0 | 95.0  | 68.2 | +0.33 | 5.29                 | 112.3 | 107.0 | -2.15  |  |  |
| 9                                                                          | Florida      | SEC  | 13-5 | +29.57 | 125.6 | 96.1  | 70.4 | -0.90 | 12.33                | 117.9 | 105.6 | +6.97  |  |  |
| 10                                                                         | Michigan St. | B10  | 16-2 | +29.32 | 120.0 | 90.7  | 66.3 | -0.32 | 8.60                 | 116.7 | 108.1 | +2.69  |  |  |
| 11                                                                         | Connecticut  | BE   | 18-1 | +28.74 | 121.9 | 93.2  | 65.5 | +0.87 | 9.44                 | 114.6 | 105.2 | +7.69  |  |  |
| 12                                                                         | Vanderbilt   | SEC  | 16-2 | +28.13 | 127.1 | 98.9  | 71.2 | +0.32 | 7.96                 | 115.1 | 107.1 | +1.72  |  |  |
| 13                                                                         | Nebraska     | B10  | 18-0 | +27.06 | 123.5 | 96.5  | 67.3 | +0.92 | 5.94                 | 113.8 | 107.9 | -4.60  |  |  |
| 14                                                                         | Virginia     | ACC  | 16-2 | +26.84 | 124.7 | 97.9  | 65.8 | +0.02 | 4.52                 | 113.2 | 108.7 | -3.64  |  |  |
| 15                                                                         | BYU          | B12  | 16-2 | +26.70 | 125.2 | 98.5  | 70.8 | +0.40 | 7.19                 | 113.9 | 106.8 | +3.71  |  |  |
| 16                                                                         | Louisville   | ACC  | 13-5 | +26.05 | 126.9 | 100.9 | 70.3 | -0.54 | 7.76                 | 113.2 | 105.4 | +2.11  |  |  |
| 17                                                                         | Alabama      | SEC  | 13-5 | +25.46 | 129.4 | 104.0 | 73.8 | -0.04 | 14.83                | 119.1 | 104.2 | +12.50 |  |  |
| 18                                                                         | Iowa         | B10  | 13-5 | +25.37 | 123.0 | 97.7  | 63.9 | -0.70 | 4.71                 | 112.3 | 107.6 | -7.12  |  |  |
| 19                                                                         | Kansas       | B12  | 13-5 | +25.25 | 122.0 | 96.8  | 67.8 | -0.16 | 12.99                | 116.4 | 103.4 | +10.51 |  |  |
| 20                                                                         | St. John's   | BE   | 13-5 | +24.44 | 123.1 | 98.7  | 70.9 | -0.64 | 9.28                 | 115.8 | 106.5 | +7.09  |  |  |

Figure 2. The first 20 teams of the KenPom data table.

The primary metrics utilized from this source include:

- Net Rating (NetRtg).
- Offensive Rating (ORTg).
- Defensive Rating (DRtg).
- Adjusted Tempo (AdjT).

Net rating is the differential between Offensive and Defensive Rating.

Offensive Rating measures the points scored per 100 possessions. Similarly, defensive rating measure the points given up per 100 possessions. These ratings are adjusted by the quality of opponents a team has played, and the game location. Lastly, Adjusted tempo is the number of possessions per 40 minutes. We define a possession as the period where a team controls the ball, ending with a shot attempt, turnover, or score.



- Adjusted Offensive Efficiency (ADJOE).
- Adjusted Defensive Efficiency (ADJDE).
- Adjusted Tempo (ADJ T.).

| RK | TEAM        | CONF | G  | REC  | D-I AVG: |       | 110.2    |      | 0.65 |      | EFF. FG% 35.3 |      | TURNOVERS 17.2 |      | REBOUNDS 30.6 |      | FT RATE 56.6 |      | 3-PT% 51.7 |      | 3-PT% 51.8 |       | SP RATE 35.7 |      | 3PT% 47.7 |  | WAB |
|----|-------------|------|----|------|----------|-------|----------|------|------|------|---------------|------|----------------|------|---------------|------|--------------|------|------------|------|------------|-------|--------------|------|-----------|--|-----|
|    |             |      |    |      | ADJUE    | ADJUE | BARTHING | EGON | EGON | TOR  | TOR           | DRB  | DRB            | FTR  | FTRD          | 3PM  | 3PMD         | 3PM  | 3PMD       | 3PM  | 3PMD       | ADJ.T | ADJ.T        |      |           |  |     |
| 1  | Michigan    | B10  | 17 | 16-1 | 128.8    | 91.0  | .8818    | 59.3 | 42.3 | 16.1 | 17.2          | 35.0 | 28.4           | 70   | 28            | 1    | 63.9         | 40.4 | 35.4       | 30.1 | 42.8       | 41.7  | 73.8         | 7    | +5.6      |  |     |
| 2  | Houston     | B12  | 18 | 17-1 | 125.4    | 92.7  | .9701    | 52.1 | 45.7 | 13.2 | 23.7          | 38.8 | 30.9           | 25.0 | 38.1          | 52.8 | 45.7         | 34.2 | 30.5       | 42.1 | 43.3       | 63.6  | 4            | +8   |           |  |     |
| 3  | Arizona     | B12  | 18 | 18-0 | 125.8    | 93.6  | .9676    | 57.0 | 45.8 | 16.2 | 16.2          | 40.3 | 25.0           | 43.1 | 29.1          | 57.9 | 44.3         | 38.5 | 32.3       | 27.4 | 36.1       | 71.8  | 3            | +6.3 |           |  |     |
| 4  | Connecticut | BE   | 19 | 18-1 | 122.2    | 92.4  | .9616    | 55.3 | 43.6 | 16.6 | 19.5          | 34.6 | 29.1           | 31.9 | 38.8          | 57.2 | 44.8         | 34.7 | 27.5       | 37.6 | 33.8       | 65.3  | 3            | +6.4 |           |  |     |
| 5  | Purdue      | B10  | 18 | 17-1 | 129.3    | 98.1  | .9598    | 58.8 | 48.8 | 14.2 | 16.4          | 37.0 | 26.7           | 28.1 | 22.1          | 58.9 | 51.0         | 39.2 | 30.6       | 38.4 | 44.5       | 65.7  | 5            | +5.7 |           |  |     |
| 6  | Illinois    | B10  | 18 | 15-3 | 130.6    | 99.3  | .9591    | 55.8 | 45.9 | 14.6 | 12.3          | 39.7 | 27.5           | 33.8 | 19.1          | 58.8 | 45.1         | 35.1 | 31.4       | 48.6 | 40.6       | 66.3  | 4            | +4.0 |           |  |     |
| 7  | Vanderbilt  | SEC  | 18 | 16-2 | 128.6    | 97.8  | .9586    | 57.8 | 46.8 | 13.1 | 18.7          | 38.0 | 27.5           | 38.1 | 43.0          | 59.9 | 49.1         | 38.8 | 28.8       | 44.3 | 40.3       | 70.9  | 7            | +4.3 |           |  |     |
| 8  | Virginia    | ACC  | 18 | 16-2 | 126.5    | 97.0  | .9546    | 56.0 | 43.5 | 15.8 | 16.4          | 40.6 | 30.4           | 36.4 | 35.2          | 56.3 | 31.6         | 37.1 | 28.9       | 40.5 | 37.2       | 65.6  | 3            | +3.8 |           |  |     |
| 9  | Florida     | SEC  | 18 | 13-5 | 125.7    | 96.6  | .9542    | 52.4 | 47.1 | 17.0 | 17.2          | 43.5 | 23.2           | 40.8 | 36.0          | 59.0 | 45.5         | 26.4 | 33.6       | 40.4 | 33.5       | 70.0  | 2            | +2.6 |           |  |     |
| 10 | Zionaga     | WCC  | 20 | 19-1 | 124.8    | 96.0  | .9536    | 57.7 | 45.6 | 14.5 | 20.5          | 37.3 | 24.5           | 30.6 | 32.0          | 58.8 | 46.6         | 36.8 | 29.8       | 29.9 | 44.7       | 70.3  | 3            | +5   |           |  |     |

Figure 3. The first 10 teams of the Barttorvik table

To complement the efficiency metrics provided by Pomeroy and Torvik, this research also incorporates the comprehensive ranking systems aggregated by Kenneth Massey. While the previously discussed datasets focus on raw predictive efficiency, the Massey Ordinals provide a consolidated view of team hierarchy. This dataset aggregates rankings from over 40 distinct

mathematical systems, pollsters, and algorithms. These rankings typically present data as an ordinal integer where the top team is assigned the value of 1. Incorporating this data allows the model to leverage a "wisdom of the crowd" approach by utilizing the consensus of the broader analytical community.

| TEAM        | SORT | DP | EBP | EMK | ENG | ESR | FAS | HAS | INC | JNG | KPK | LOG | MAS | MB | MGS |
|-------------|------|----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|----|-----|
| Arizona     | >>   | 4  | 5   | 2   | 2   | 1   | 1   | 4   | 2   | 1   | 3   | 2   | 1   | 1  | 2   |
| Michigan    | >>   | 1  | 2   | 1   | 1   | 6   | 3   | 1   | 1   | 4   | 1   | 1   | 6   | 6  | 4   |
| Duke        | >>   | 2  | 1   | 3   | 7   | 4   | 4   | 2   | 3   | 2   | 2   | 3   | 2   | 5  | 5   |
| Purdue      | >>   | 7  | 6   | 5   | 3   | 5   | 6   | 3   | 5   | 6   | 4   | 5   | 4   | 4  | 3   |
| Gonzaga     | >>   | 3  | 3   | 9   | 9   | 7   | 7   | 7   | 6   | 9   | 5   | 4   | 5   | 7  | 1   |
| Connecticut | >>   | 13 | 11  | 6   | 5   | 3   | 5   | 15  | 7   | 5   | 6   | 7   | 7   | 3  | 6   |
| Houston     | >>   | 5  | 4   | 4   | 6   | 8   | 9   | 8   | 4   | 7   | 8   | 12  | 3   | 8  | 9   |

Figure 4. A sample of the Massey Ordinals table showing distinct ranking systems.

One significant challenge in aggregating these distinct sources is the inconsistency in team nomenclature. For instance, a university might be listed as "St. Mary's" in one dataset and "Saint Mary's CA" in another. To resolve this discrepancy, all external data was strictly mapped to the unique TeamID integer provided by the Kaggle competition files. This standardization ensures that the advanced efficiency metrics are accurately merged with the box score data for every specific matchup.

## LITERATURE REVIEW

### Past Strategies

The pursuit of a perfect bracket has generated a substantial body of research in predictive modeling over the last decade. While specific algorithms vary, the most successful strategies in the Kaggle Machine Learning Mania competition consistently rely on one of two distinct methodological frameworks.

The primary objective for this study is to minimize the Brier Score. We define the Brier Score (BS) as follows:

$$(1) \quad BS = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{t=1}^N (f_t - o_t)^2$$

where  $N$  is the number of events,  $f_t$  is the predicted probability, and  $o_t$  is the actual outcome. For this research, a 0 is considered a loss, and a 1 is a win. A Brier Score of 0 would reflect perfect accuracy, while a Brier Score of 1 reflects perfect inaccuracy. To provide a baseline, a strategy where we predict every team has a 50% chance of winning would result in a Brier Score of 0.25. (thinking of putting another example here)

The first framework relies on fundamental analysis where the objective is to construct a ground-truth probability independent of public sentiment. A common implementation of this approach involves utilizing domain-specific heuristics such as the elo rating system. Originally designed for chess, elo provides a dynamic measure of team strength that updates after every game. It offers a robust baseline that accounts for strength of schedule more

effectively than raw win-loss records [?]. Many strategies also incorporate expert features. These include the Nate Silver, FiveThirtyEight, and KenPom ratings which act as high-signal inputs that aggregate player health, travel distance, and roster depth into a single numeric value. By treating these expert outputs as features rather than final predictions, modelers can leverage human domain expertise while correcting for known expert biases.

The second dominant framework relies on the Efficient Market Hypothesis [?]. This approach posits that global betting markets, specifically closing lines from major bookmakers, offer a more accurate aggregate predictor of game outcomes than individual statistical models. The efficacy of this strategy is well-documented in recent Kaggle competitions where five of the top eight performing models utilized market-derived features as their primary feature. These strategies do not attempt to beat the market. Instead, they focus on mathematically disentangling the true win probability from the bookmaker’s overround and inherent biases.

To achieve this, recent state-of-the-art implementations utilize specific conversion algorithms to de-noise betting data. The standard tool in this domain is the *Goto\_conversion*. Competitors employ these functions to address the favorite-longshot bias. This is the tendency for markets to overvalue underdogs and undervalue favorites. By applying these corrections, modelers can transform raw Vegas odds into highly calibrated probabilities that minimize Brier Score more effectively than fundamental analysis alone. This approach effectively leverages the crowd wisdom of the market while stripping away the pricing inefficiencies introduced by public betting behavior. For more information on how this strategy works, we refer the reader to [?].

The applicability of these methodological frameworks, however, is heavily constrained by the structural discontinuity introduced by the 2021 Name, Image, and Likeness (NIL) legislation. Statistical analysis of the post-NIL landscape reveals a significant deviation from historical norms, characterized by a rapid consolidation of talent where the number of programs with elite win percentages (  $> 75\%$ ) has nearly tripled [?]. This phenomenon implies that feature weights derived from pre-2021 eras are likely subject to significant concept drift. Consequently, this literature review restricts its focus to winning strategies from recent Kaggle competitions (2022-present), as methodologies developed before the NIL era may not reflect the approaches best suited to the heightened stratification of team strength driven by current transfer portal dynamics.

### Modeling Techniques

Recent tournament prediction methodologies employ several established modeling and computational techniques. This section provides formal definitions for the five core approaches used in this study: Logistic Regression, Linear Regression, Monte Carlo Simulation, Random Forest, and Neural Networks.

Logistic Regression is a binary classification model that estimates the probability of an outcome by applying the logistic (also known as sigmoid) function to a linear combination of input features. The model is defined as:

$$(2) \quad P(Y = 1|X) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-(\beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \beta_2 x_2 + \dots + \beta_n x_n)}}$$

where  $Y$  is the binary outcome,  $X = (x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n)$  represents the feature vector, and  $\beta = (\beta_0, \beta_1, \dots, \beta_n)$  are the model coefficients estimated through the maximum likelihood estimation. This function ensures the predicted probabilities are bounded between  $[0, 1]$ . Logistic regression assumes a linear relationship between the input features and the log-odds of the outcome. This assumption can be restrictive when the true relationships are nonlinear. To address this limitation, common approaches are feature engineering with polynomial or interaction terms (e.g.,  $x^2, x_i \cdot x_j$ ) to capture nonlinear patterns.

Linear Regression is a supervised learning method that models the relationship between a dependent variable and one or more independent variables by fitting a linear equation to the observed data. Linear Regression

is defined as:

$$(3) \quad \hat{Y} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \beta_2 x_2 + \dots + \beta_n x_n$$

where  $\hat{Y}$  is the predicted continuous outcome,  $X = (x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n)$  represents the vector of features, and  $\beta = (\beta_0, \beta_1, \dots, \beta_n)$  are the model coefficients estimated through ordinary least squares (OLS) minimization. For more information on OLS we refer the reader to [?]. Unlike logistic regression, linear regression produces unbounded predictions and does not inherently output probabilities. In sports prediction contexts, linear regression is commonly used to estimate point totals, scoring margins, or other continuous performance metrics that can subsequently be transformed into win probabilities through additional techniques.

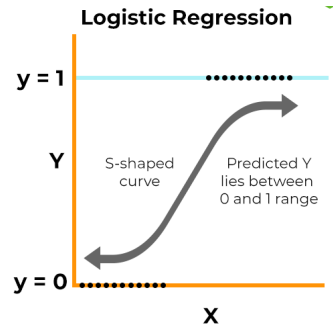


Figure 5. An Example of a Logistic Regression Equation [?].

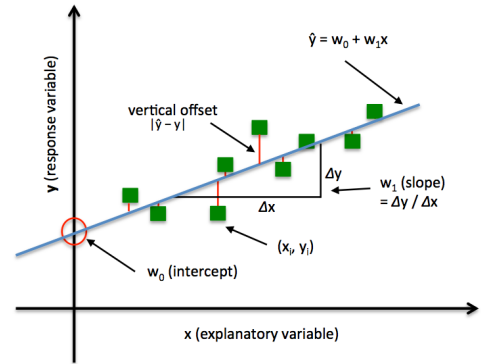


Figure 6. An Example of a Linear Regression Equation [?].

Monte Carlo Simulation is a computational technique that uses repeated random sampling to estimate probabilities for systems with inherent uncertainty. The method generates  $N$  independent samples  $x_1, x_2, \dots, x_N$

from a probability distribution  $f(x)$ , then estimates probabilities by computation the proportion of samples satisfying a certain condition. The simulation is defined as:

$$(4) \quad \hat{P} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N 1(x_i \in A)$$

where  $1(\cdot)$  is the indicator function that equals 1 when the condition is satisfied and 0 otherwise.  $A$  represents the event of interest, and  $\hat{P}$  is the Monte Carlo estimate of the true probability  $P(A)$ . By the Law of Large Numbers [?],  $\hat{P} \rightarrow P(A)$  as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ . In sports prediction contexts, Monte Carlo methods are frequently employed to simulate game outcomes by sampling from estimated score distributions, enabling the estimation of win probabilities through empirical frequency counts across simulated matchups.

XGBoost (Extreme Gradient Boosting), considered a "black-box" approach, is an ensemble learning method that constructs a sequence of decision trees where each successive tree is trained to correct the residual errors of the previous trees. Unlike Random Forest, which builds trees independently, XGBoost employs gradient boosting to iteratively minimize a loss function through additive modeling [?]. The model prediction is defined as the sum of predictions from all trees:

$$(5) \quad \hat{y}_i = \sum_{k=1}^K f_k(x_i).$$



Here,  $f_k(x_i)$  is the prediction of the  $k^{\text{th}}$  tree for the  $i^{\text{th}}$  data point,  $\hat{y}_i$  is the final predicted value for the  $i^{\text{th}}$  data point, and  $K$  is the number of trees.

Each tree is trained to minimize the objective function

$$(6) \quad \text{obj}(\theta) = \sum_i^n l(y_i, \hat{y}_i) + \sum_{k=1}^K \Omega(f_k)$$

where  $l$  is the loss function which simply computes the difference between the true and predicted, and  $\Omega$  is the regularization term, discouraging overly complex trees. The optimization process then proceeds via gradient descent on the residuals. For more information regarding gradient descent we refer the reader to [?]. XGBoost is widely adopted in competitive machine learning for its performance on structured data and ability to capture complex interactions and relationships between features.

Neural Networks are a class of machine learning models inspired by biological neural systems, consisting of interconnected layers of computational nodes (neurons) that learn hierarchical feature representations through iterative optimization. A feedforward neural network transforms input features through multiple layers of weighted connections and nonlinear activation functions.

For a network with  $L$  layers, the output at layer  $\ell$  is computed as

$$(7) \quad h^{(\ell)} = \sigma(W^{(\ell)}h^{(\ell-1)} + b^{(\ell)})$$

if i do neural nets i will keep going with this.

## Binary Prediction Models

### Data Cleaning

1 if team A won 0 if team A loss for each game considering  
training/testing strategies why i chose what i did (amount of data/ why reg  
season?) why only that year?

### Variable Selection

### Logistic Regression

### Boosting

### Results

Here are my insights...

## Point Spread Models

same as above

S

Here are my insights...

Comparison of models

My Contributions and Analysis

Here are my insights...

2026 Competition

Strategies

Here are my insights...

Results

## CONCLUSIONS

### Summary

As a preliminary assessment...